

Worship by Teaching and Example

Someone asked me, "If you had only four consecutive hours each week to lock yourself away, while the rest of your prayer time came in stolen moments, how would you spend those four hours most productively in God's presence?"

Part of that time would be praying in tongues. Then there would be worship and confession of the Word, which can also be joined to worship:

Speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs...

This is a way to minister to your own heart with God's Word, encouraging yourself and building yourself up on your most holy faith. In a six-, seven-, or eight-hour period, I often move among all three and then cycle through them again.

With only three or four hours, I would generally begin by praying in tongues. After an hour or so, a definite quieting occurs in the mind. The mind seems to possess energy of its own, like a snowball rolling downhill and gathering momentum. At first, I tried to force mine to think only about the Word while I prayed. Fifteen minutes later, I would discover it had wandered away to explore something else.

Eventually I stopped fighting every movement and simply guided it away from wrong areas. I also discovered I could read the Word while praying in tongues, and I did that hour after hour. At times a stronger anointing came during prayer; then I laid the Bible down and yielded to the force of the tongues, perhaps entering another degree of edification or intercession.

After praying for a while, Isaiah 28 begins to operate:

This is the rest wherewith ye may cause the weary to rest; and this is the refreshing.

When I first prayed for extended periods, I walked along a riverbed in Oregon. To occupy my mind, I kicked every green rock and picked red leaves from bushes. It took a long time to quiet down.

But the longer I prayed, the quieter my mind became until it was content simply to rest. Then I understood that it had become receptive to revelation knowledge, wisdom, and what God wanted to impart.

Sometimes you go to bed with a problem wearing on you. It is the last thing you feed into your spirit before sleep. Often you are searching for the answer along a familiar but wrong path. Because that path solved earlier problems, you assume the answer must be there. Even if the Holy Ghost tries to approach, you cannot hear Him because your thinking has already run far down that road.

After sleeping, however, the mind is momentarily neutral when your eyes first open. Before it can jump back onto the wrong path, the Holy Spirit may place the answer before you. You awaken saying, "I know what to do!" He finally got through because you woke outside the rut.

Doctrine and tradition can place the mind on wrong paths in the same way. Extended prayer in tongues can produce while awake what sleep produced overnight. The mind settles into rest and becomes receptive to the mysteries taught by the Holy Ghost.

If I had four hours, I might therefore pray in tongues for the first hour or hour and a half. Then I would worship for an hour, with my mind better able to submit to the King as I offered my soul. Finally, I would worship through the Word concerning whatever petition or problem needed to be addressed.

In this service, however, we are dealing only with offering the soul in worship.

We are going to worship as though each person were alone in a prayer closet. In a moment, I will shut you out. Even if you sit next to me, you will not be able to enter my attention, because the only Person I will worship is the Lord Jesus Christ.

I once pleaded with the Holy Spirit, "You will have to teach me. I do not know how to offer my soul effectively in worship. Please teach me, because this is vital to knowing Him."

Faith does not beg for what already belongs to us, but I begged for this understanding. I had imagined that I wanted to know God more than He wanted to know me. That is wrong. He desires and even craves our fellowship. He created us for fellowship, not merely to release us into the world and watch our lives pass.

As the Spirit taught me, it initially took time to enter worship. Once I did, the presence that came through worship felt different from the edification of tongues. Worship affected my soul and senses, whereas tongues affected my spirit.

Paul says, "If I pray in an unknown tongue, my spirit prayeth." If the human spirit prays under the Holy Spirit's power, it stands to reason that the human spirit receives the answer. When I desire edification, I pray in tongues. When I desire the immediate manifestation of His presence, I worship until He comes.

I have never found circumstances in which, after overcoming the flesh and lifting my hands in worship, He refused to come.

When I asked the Holy Spirit to teach me worship, He said, "Learn to worship Me the same way Jesus taught you to enter the Father's presence."

Matthew 6 says:

 Your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him.

I asked, "If You already know what I need and have read the petition before I present it in Jesus' name, why must I pray?"

Then I understood that the Lord's Prayer describes conditions that make petition effective.

After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name.

Kenneth Hagin used to say that whenever you see "therefore," you should find out what it is there for. Because the Father knows the petition before we approach Him, Jesus tells us how to approach. We begin with worship, praise, and thanksgiving: "Holy is Your name."

Then comes:

Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread.

These verses form one thought. They correspond to the conclusion of the chapter:

Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

We consecrate our lives to make God's heavenly will manifest on earth. Then daily provision is added. It makes little sense to demand daily bread while caring nothing for the kingdom's work.

Forgiveness is another prerequisite to petition. Jesus said that mountain-moving faith can command a mountain to be cast into the sea, but while standing in prayer we must forgive anyone against whom we hold anything.

The Father already knows our request. If we want it answered, we enter with worship, consecrate ourselves to His will, and walk in forgiveness.

And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil.

This asks God to lead us around tests, trials, temptations, and the evil one's snares. Entering with worship, submitting to God's will, and walking in forgiveness avoids many of those snares.

Forgiveness carries so much weight that Jesus repeated it after the prayer:

For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you:
But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

When approaching the Godhead with a petition, we should learn respect and protocol. The Holy Spirit brings us into Jesus' presence. Jesus, through the use of His name, brings us into the Father's presence to lay the petition at His feet.

In an emergency, such as a truck bearing down on you, there may be no time for an hour of worship; call the name of Jesus. But when time permits a deliberate approach, remember who you are, who He is, and the distinct roles of the Godhead.

Jesus says:

And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are: for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets, that they may be seen of men.

A hypocrite lives behind a mask, showing people only the desired exterior. If nobody watched, there would be no reason for such a person to pray.

But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

He also warns against vain repetitions as though many words could force God to hear. Proper worship may repeat truth as it ministers to and transforms the soul, but chanting does not move God.

Jesus was teaching me to enter privately. A group setting does not change that principle. Close your eyes, lift your hands, and shut out the world. I can find my closet in an airport terminal. The secret place is available wherever I deliberately turn my whole attention to Him.

God showed me this during an international Full Gospel meeting in Brazil. Six or seven thousand people attended, and I was asked to minister to perhaps one or two thousand young people. Bernard translated for me.

Their music was extremely loud and wild, and it grated on my spirit. Finally I asked Bernard to stop them. I said, "We are going to worship from the private sanctuary of our hearts. Stop the music. Close your eyes, lift your hands, and choose your own words from your own priesthood to tell Jesus how much you love Him."

I began: "I love You, Jesus. I worship, glorify, and praise You."

Mine was the only voice, with Bernard translating. After a while I peeked. Everyone was peeking at everyone else to see who would begin. I discovered that they did not know how to enter for themselves.

Music can carry people. It supplies rhythm and emotional energy, while projected lyrics supply the thoughts. A person can sing with the crowd, appear to worship, and still hate the person beside him. The thoughts and emotions are being supplied from outside.

Private worship is different. You choose words of adoration from your own priesthood, shut everyone else out, and tell Him how much you love Him.

The soul consists of mind, will, intellect, and emotions. With the spirit, I contact God; with the body, I contact physical things; and with the soul, I contact other people through accumulated knowledge and communication.

In worship I offer God the very part of myself through which I contact humanity. I offer my whole mind, will, intellect, and emotions.

When I began, I would say, "I love You. I praise You. I glorify You," while my voice seemed to trail into the distance and my mind wandered down the street to solve yesterday's problem.

I had to retrieve my mind and bring it into subjection: "No, you do not. I am in the presence of the King. I will respect Him by offering my whole soul, not giving lip service while the rest of me wanders away."

Even if there were a three-second pause between statements, I made sure all of me entered each one:

"I love You, Jesus. I glorify You. I praise You. I magnify You."

It is not the number of words, but how much of yourself you pour into them. Whenever the mind wandered, I stopped, gathered it, and offered it again.

Before long, the Holy Spirit rose within and took ascendancy over my senses. Most believers have experienced a move of God in which the senses seem drowned in an anointing of worship and no one wants to stop. God wants us to know that we can deliberately find that place.

At first you may feel dry, like frozen meat that must thaw. The day's problems crowd the mind. Keep collecting the soul, bringing it back, and offering it. Eventually the Spirit charges your human spirit until it rises above the senses and draws them into worship. The presence of God manifests.

Then Jesus takes you by the arm, leads you beyond the brazen altar into the holiest place, and receives your petition. That is answered prayer.

Speak loudly enough to demand your soul's attention. Statements of adoration are especially useful.

"Thank You for providing healing" is grateful recognition of what He has done. Adoration is the heart itself going to Him:

"I love You. I worship You. I glorify and magnify Your holy name. I bless the day I was born again. I exalt and extol You."

Six or seven sincere statements are enough. The issue is not an elaborate vocabulary but how fully you pour yourself into each statement.

Learn private worship. Worship leaders cannot follow you everywhere to manufacture an atmosphere. If you are stranded in a desert with dead batteries and no earphones, you must still know how to worship. Anywhere and anytime, we can pass the flesh at the brazen altar, offer the body as a living sacrifice, and continue toward the holiest place.

Private worship will make hypocrisy uncomfortable. A person can wear a mask in church, but in secret worship there is nowhere for the false exterior to perform.

Jesus is my best friend, confidant, Savior, God, and glorified Brother. When I approach Him with a petition, He is also my High Priest and King. I will use proper protocol and refuse Him the disrespect of lip service. I will gather my wandering mind again and again until I enter true worship.

There is nobody beside you now. You are in your closet. Let us begin.

Jesus, I glorify You, praise You, and worship You. I love You, Jesus. I magnify Your holy name.

Hallelujah. I bless and adore You. I bless the day I was born again and could call You my Savior. I love You and exalt You. I praise, worship, and magnify You.

Hallelujah, Jesus. Glory to Your holy name. I love You, Jesus. Yes, I love You. I praise and worship You. I glorify and adore You.

My name is written in heaven. I bless You, Jesus. I worship and magnify You. Hallelujah.

You are beginning to come, Jesus. Glory, glory, glory. Thank You for Your presence. Even so, come, Lord Jesus. I worship, glorify, and praise You.

My King of kings and Lord of glory, I praise You. I magnify, worship, and glorify You. I love You, Jesus. I bless the day I could call You my Savior.

Hallelujah. I worship You. I glorify You. I praise and magnify You. Thank You for blessing me, Jesus.

He is blessing me so much that I am going to have to cut you loose to worship Him.